



Asia

Azerbaijan

Mugham music

These musicians and poets have gathered together to make improvised traditional Azerbaijani folk music called mugham.



- 33,436 sq miles (86,600 sq km)
- 10.2 million
- Baku
- Azeri, Russian

Azerbaijan is **rich** in **petroleum** and **natural gas** reserves. In some places, **burning gas** seeps out of the ground and **stays ablaze** for years on end. For this reason, **Azerbaijan** has been called “the **land of fire**.”

Mud volcanoes
In Gobustan National Park, southwest of Baku, there are almost 300 mud volcanoes. These are not true volcanoes (made of lava) but formed by eruptions of mud and gas.



0 100 km
0 100 miles
(approximate scale)

City landmark

The Heydar Aliyev Center in Baku is a hub for Azerbaijani culture. It is famous for its wavelike design.



Syria

Raising water

Giant waterwheels called norias were once used to raise water in irrigation systems around the city of Hama. The wheels (below) date from the 14th century.

The waterwheels are turned by the flow of the Orontes River.



0 75 km
0 75 miles
(approximate scale)



Bustling bazaar

The Al-Hamidiyah souk in Damascus is Syria's biggest market. It sells handicrafts, clothes, and groceries.



- 72,370 sq miles (187,437 sq km)
- 19.4 million
- Damascus
- Arabic, other languages (7+)

Syria has a **rich history**—its capital, Damascus, has been **inhabited since 8000 BCE**. The country has experienced **turbulence** in recent years due to a **civil war** that began in **2011**, which has forced millions of people to flee their homeland.